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PREVIEW

Su Shih's Art of Writing and His Han-shih t'ieh

Bor-hua Wang

Submitted in partial fulfillment of the
requirements for the degree
of Doctor of Philosophy
in the Graduate School of Arts and Sciences

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PREVIEW

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ABSTRACT

Su Shih's Art of Writing and His Han-shih t'ieh

Bor-hua Wang

This dissertation on Su Shih (1037-1101), one of the most complex cultural figures in Chinese history, focuses on him mainly as a calligrapher. Su Shih's masterpiece, the Han-shih t'ieh (Scroll of the Poems of the Cold-Food Festival) is taken as the focal point for discussion.

Chapter I presents a biographical account of Su Shih's life to set the background of his art; the discussion focuses on his struggle between a public life in government and a wish to retire from society completely.

Chapter II analyzes and interprets the calligraphic style of the Han-shih t'ieh. Su Shih's thought on calligraphy sets the foundation for the interpretation, however, Huang T'ing-chien's colophon to the Han-shih t'ieh is taken as the point of departure for discussion.

Chapter III discusses Su Shih's relationship with the calligraphic tradition that preceded him. The Han-shih t'ieh and Su Shih's other works are compared with works by

traditional masters to trace Su Shih's formal training in the art of writing.

Chapter IV compares the Han-shih t'ieh with Su Shih's other works that are stylistically related. I contend that Su wrote the Han-shih t'ieh in the Yüan-yu (1086-1093) era when he was serving in the Han-lin academy in K'ai-feng. My contention thus runs counter with what is generally believed that Su wrote the scroll earlier in the Yüan-feng (1078-1085) era while he was living in exile in Huang-chou.

Chapter V discusses Su Shih's legacy and influence in the realm of calligraphy and concludes that Su was a master with few significant followers in terms of formal influence. Nonetheless, Su Shih's major inspiration was that calligraphy is an art of self-expression on a par with poetry, and this thesis continues to influence calligraphers of later generations.

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